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NOT ON THE SAME PAGE
Imran Khan and Pakistan President Arif Alvi (third from right) at the 2022 Pakistan Day parade with the military top brass

ask Buzdar to resign to accommodate PML-Q's Elahi in the CM's slot. Elahi had made a bid to grab the coveted chief ministership as a quid pro quo for continuing to support Imran. But it was much too late. In the words of opposition politician Maulana Fazlur Rehman, "the floodwaters had already gone above the head".

However, the real rupture with the military took place last year, when Gen. Bajwa attempted to move Lt Gen. Faiz Hameed out of the ISI into a corps posting. On the face of it, it was a normal change of commands. But Imran resisted. He claimed he wanted to retain Gen. Hameed because of the rapidly changing situation in Afghanistan after the Taliban takeover, but most felt he saw in Gen. Hameed a dependable ally since, as the ISI head, he was the main political manipulator and troubleshooter for the PTI. It was also

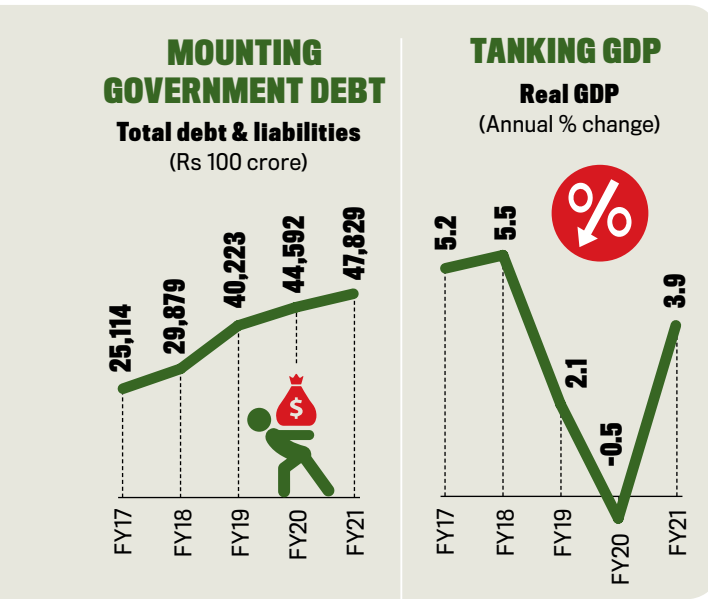
WITH THE PTI GOVERNMENT'S POOR HANDLING OF THE ECONOMY AND GOVERNANCE, PUBLIC BRICKBATS WERE DIRECTED AT THE ARMY AS WELL

widely speculated that Imran wanted to appoint him as army chief on the completion of Gen. Bajwa's extended tenure this November. On the other hand, many saw the move as Gen. Bajwa wanting to row back the political involvement of the army.

Whatever the truth, Imran's resistance created a crisis within the army, because a lot of appointments were inordinately delayed for over a month. But more than anything, it indicated that Imran was trying to interfere in the internal affairs of the army, crossing an unspoken red line for civilians. He had to back down eventually, but Imran had forfeited the trust he shared with the army. When Gen. Bajwa apparently told Imran earlier this year that the army would henceforth remain "neutral" in politics, he did not take it well. Reports from within the PM's House indicate he lashed out in private, probably assuming it as a sign that the army was willing to strike a deal with his opponents. He lashed out in public too, without naming anyone. "What is 'neutral' [in the fight between good and evil]?" he thundered at a public rally in March. "Only animals are neutral!" Surreptitiously, PTI's social media troll brigade also began to launch pointed attacks on Gen. Bajwa in particular, further vitiating the atmosphere between the two main power centres in Pakistan.

THE DENOUEMENT AND AFTER

PTI insiders are convinced that the army's top brass ditched Imran and that its 'neutrality' stance was a signal to the opposition, since its leaders had long been demanding that the



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